



Time: 5 minutes

Outcome: Interpret debt levels, debt-to-GDP ratios, and interest burdens.

Difficulty: Intermediate

Debt Measures, Debt Burden, and Fiscal Data

THE CORE IDEA

The debt level is a nominal dollar stock; the debt-to-GDP ratio compares that stock with the economy's annual income and productive capacity. Ratios support comparisons across time and economies, but they do not by themselves prove sustainability. Interest rates, economic growth, revenues, primary balances, maturity, and investor confidence also matter at a Principles level.

HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- Debt-to-GDP = public debt divided by nominal GDP, multiplied by 100 percent.
- Debt can rise while debt-to-GDP falls if nominal GDP grows faster.
- Interest burden can be compared with GDP, revenue, or total outlays.
- Nominal levels answer size questions; ratios answer size-relative-to-capacity questions.

WATCH OUT

Do not interpret one ratio as a mechanical crisis threshold. Use consistent definitions and dates, then combine the ratio with growth, interest costs, and budget information.

WORKED EXAMPLE: LEVEL UP, RATIO DOWN

Debt levels versus debt-to-GDP

	Before	After
Debt	\$6.0 trillion	\$6.6 trillion
Nominal GDP	\$24.0 trillion	\$27.5 trillion
Debt / GDP	25.0%	24.0%

Debt rises from \$6.0 trillion to \$6.6 trillion while nominal GDP rises from \$24.0 trillion to \$27.5 trillion. Debt-to-GDP moves from 25.0% to 24.0%. The debt level increased, but the economy's nominal scale grew faster, so the relative measure fell.

CHECK YOURSELF

Debt is \$9 trillion and nominal GDP is \$30 trillion. What is the debt-to-GDP ratio?